



# OSINT (Open-Source Intelligence) Checklist

This checklist ensures thoroughness, legality and ethical compliance during investigations.

## 1. Preparation

### Define Objectives

Clarify the target (person, organization, event, or technical system).

Set scope: time frame, geography, and data types (e.g., financial records, social media).

### Legal & Ethical Compliance

Review GDPR, CCPA, CFAA, and local laws.

Avoid terms of service violations (e.g., scraping restricted sites).

Adhere to ethical guidelines (no doxxing, harassment, or unauthorized access).

### Tools & Resources

Prepare tools: search engines, Shodan, theHarvester, SpiderFoot, etc.

Bookmark databases: WHOIS, EDGAR, OpenCorporates, national registries.

### Secure Environment

Use VPNs, Tor, or secure browsers (Brave, Firefox with privacy plugins).

Set up a virtual machine (e.g., Kali Linux) for sensitive tasks.

## 2. Data Collection Phase

### a. People

#### Search Engines

Advanced operators: site:, filetype:pdf, intitle:, inurl:.

Reverse image search (Google Images, TinEye).

#### Social Media

Platforms: Analysis across leading social media platforms.

Tools: Social Searcher, Sherlock (username lookup), Holehe (email lookup).



## 2. Data Collection Phase

### a. People (cont.)

#### Emails/Phones

Verify breaches: HaveIBeenPwned, DeHashed.

Reverse phone lookup: Truecaller, Whitepages.

#### Public Records

Court documents (PACER), property records (Zillow), voter registrations.

Genealogy sites: Ancestry, FamilySearch.

### b. Organizations

#### Website Analysis

WHOIS lookup, DNS history (SecurityTrails), Wayback Machine archives.

SSL certificates (crt.sh).

#### Financial/Legal

SEC filings (EDGAR), business registries (OpenCorporates), sanctions

#### Employee Data

LinkedIn employees, GitHub repositories, conference speaker lists.

### c. Events

#### News/Media

Google News, Factiva, local news outlets.

Verify viral content: InVID, OSINT Collective online.

#### Geospatial

Google Earth, Sentinel Hub, SunCalc (shadow analysis).

Social media geotags and EXIF data (ExifTool).

### d. Technical Systems

#### Network Analysis

Shodan (IoT devices), Censys, Nmap scans.

DNS records (MX, TXT, SPF).

#### Leaks/Dark Web

Pastebin, GhostBin, Tor forums (via OnionScan).

## 3. Analysis Phase

### Correlation

Cross-reference data (e.g., link phone numbers to social profiles).  
Use i2 for relationship mapping.

### Credibility Assessment

Check source reputation and biases.  
Timestamp verification (e.g., Wayback Machine vs. recent edits).

### Pattern Recognition

Identify recurring entities or behaviors across data points.  
Look for anomalies or inconsistencies in patterns or formats.

### Geospatial Mapping

Overlay data on maps (Google My Maps, QGIS).

## 4. Reporting Phase

### Documentation

Screenshots, archived web pages, source URLs.  
Structured report: executive summary, methodology, findings.

### Credibility Assessment

Encrypt files (VeraCrypt), store in secure drives.  
Share via encrypted channels (Signal, ProtonMail).

## 5. Post-Investigations Actions

### Review Process

Identify gaps (e.g., missed data sources).

### Data Retention

Securely delete unnecessary data (BleachBit).

### Monitoring

Set alerts (Google Alerts, Mention.com) for ongoing targets.

## 6. Additional Considerations

### Training

Stay updated via OSINT Curious, OSINT Framework, or SANS OSINT Summit recordings.

### Operational Security (OPSEC)

Use pseudonyms, burner emails, and avoid direct interaction with targets.

### Collaboration

Share findings with teams via secure platforms (Keybase, SecureDrop).



### Final Tip

Always verify findings with 2–3 independent sources to counter misinformation. Adapt tools/techniques to the investigation's context (e.g., cybersecurity vs. due diligence).



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